the systematic annihilation of indigenous religions throughout the world.[102] The writings of many revered church fathers and the official decrees of many popes and church councils are full of passages disparaging 'pagan' and 'heretical' religions, calling for their destruction, discriminating against their members and legitimising the use of violence to convert people to Christianity.[103] For example, in 1452 Pope Nicholas V issued the *Dum Diversas* bull, addressed to King Afonso V of Portugal and other Catholic monarchs. The bull said, 'We grant you by these present documents, with our Apostolic Authority, full and free permission to invade, search out, capture, and subjugate the Saracens and pagans and any other unbelievers and enemies of Christ wherever they may be, as well as their kingdoms, duchies, counties, principalities, and other property … and to reduce their persons into perpetual servitude.'[104] This official proclamation, repeated numerous times by subsequent popes, laid the theological basis for European imperialism and the destruction of native cultures across the world. Of course, though the church doesn't acknowledge it officially, over time it has changed its institutional structures, its core teachings and its interpretation of scripture. The Catholic Church of today is far less antisemitic and misogynist than it was in medieval and early modern times. Pope Francis is far more tolerant of indigenous cultures than was Pope Nicholas V. There is an institutional self-correcting mechanism at work here, which reacts both to external pressures and to internal soul-searching. But what characterises self-correcting in institutions like the Catholic Church is that even when it happens, it is denied rather than celebrated. The first rule of changing church teachings is that you never admit to changing church teachings.

You would never hear a pope announcing to the world, 'Our experts have just discovered a really big error in the Bible. We'll soon issue an updated edition.' Instead, when asked about the church's more generous attitude to Jews or women, popes imply that this was always what the church *really* taught, even if some individual churchmen previously failed to understand the message correctly. Denying the existence of self-correction doesn't entirely stop it from happening, but it does weaken and slow it. Because the correction of past mistakes is not acknowledged, let alone celebrated, when the faithful encounter another serious problem in the institution and its teachings, they are paralyzed by fear of changing something that is